

DREAMLIKE A still from *Meanwhile Elsewhere*

PUNIYA

debut in 1977 and dealing with comparisons with her mother, it didn't take her long to realise that she wanted to use the Pandanallur style of Bharatanatyam to do something that hadn't been attempted. Says Sarabhai, "Bharatanatyam, for me, is an extremely liberating form. I don't think of tradition as something to be locked in a museum. I had internalised the grammar so that I could do anything with it."

Her recent solo piece, *Past Forward*, is an example of that outlook.

It was working and touring with the renowned stage director Peter Brook for the acclaimed play, *The Mahabharata*, that became a major source of motivation for Sarabhai to go beyond dance. Mallika's decision to take Darpana from being a classical dance training and performing institute to something bigger—using multimedia and technology and light design to create dramas that are visual spectacles and producing and hosting TV shows—had the backing of her mother. It has resulted in TV shows like *Srishti: The Environment Quiz* and *Talk Positive*, a chat show which created awareness about HIV, and proscenium works like *Sita's Daughter* and *Kadak Badshahi*, a large production featuring a hundred actors that celebrated Ahmedabad's rich and diverse cultural heritage, becoming some of Darpana's popular works.

Sarabhai's hope is that *Meanwhile Elsewhere* will also resonate with a wider audience, like *Kadak Badshahi*. Inspired by one of Sarabhai's favourite books, *Invisible Cities*, it's less an adaptation and more a metaphor "for our own cities" featuring characters like Kublai Khan and Marco Polo. "It typifies Darpana's ethos and spirit in different ways but in the here and how," she says. "It has a dreamlike quality, and takes you into the recesses of the mind and heart." Much like other works, it was envisioned in Natrani, one of the most striking performance spaces in India. For both Sarabhai and Yadavan, the venue symbolises their "commitment" to the city despite it being a "difficult beast" to operate in. After re-opening in 2018, Natrani has been evolving and now includes a gallery space, besides hosting 42 performances a year.

Sarabhai has lots to look forward to in 2025. There's *Meanwhile Elsewhere*, which has a 10-day run from March 15 at Natrani, touring with other works, and digging through the archives to compile an e-scrap book to document Darpana's journey. "It's hilarious to see what kind of things happened in each year," she says. But even as she revisits the past, Sarabhai knows the show must go on in the present and the future. ■

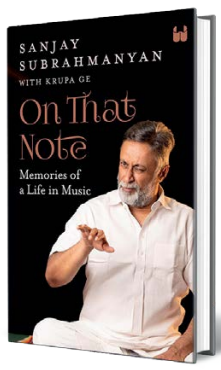
–Suhani Singh

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CELEBRATED CARNATIC VOCALIST **SANJAY SUBRAHMANYAN** RECOUNTS HIS EXTRAORDINARY JOURNEY IN THIS CANDID MEMOIR

well as to experiment with popular music. The choice was neither easy nor inevitable—in fact, his memoir, *On That Note* offers us a candid view of how he evolved as a young singer, eager to absorb as many influences as possible but remaining true to his idealised understanding of *sampradaya sangeetam*, how he matured into a seasoned artiste ready to go digital and how he finally broke the barrier to start singing for the movies.

Sanjay's story, however, is different in that it offers us an intensely personal rumination of his aspirations, his musical orientation and choices. What makes the memoir special is its candour and freshness. There is an innocence about self-expression, about the privileges of location that he enjoyed and about the time he took to make up his mind about singing in a different idiom. There is nothing staged about his choices, it is almost as if he stumbled upon them as he emerged as a celebrated singer, a young Kalanidhi awardee and then subsequently honed them carefully with practice and collaboration. The image of the boy-next-door never disappears, adding to the charm of the book. Equally poignant is the frankness with which he speaks about voice problems and how he went about addressing them.



ON THAT NOTE
Memories of a Life in Music
by Sanjay Subrahmanyan with Krupa Ge
WESTLAND
₹599; 176 pages

On That Note is really about a talented boy who found himself in an extraordinary musical milieu, was unabashed in his enthusiasm for singing and who found his calling in popularising certain genres. It makes for very attractive reading and also demystifies the singer that fans know and adore. ■

–Lakshmi Subramanian